

Cleaning the e-mail mess

A German university recently became the first organisation to publicly surrender the fight against spam and virus-loaded e-mail. The administrators turned off all filters and let through all e-mail, even though they knew 98 per cent of it was bad. Their filters just couldn't keep up.

Ever since the innocuous-sounding Melissa hit the Internet in 1999, e-mail has been the most popular, and the most effective way to deliver viruses. You can stop junk mail on your PC, but that doesn't account for all the damage that they do. E-mail viruses can usurp all available bandwidth to spread. Junk mail accounts for a huge chunk of the bandwidth available to ISPs, and if you have spent time cleaning out your Hotmail or Yahoo! account, you know how much it costs you in terms of bandwidth and productive time. The ideal goal, is to stop the junk from ever reaching your modem connection, not just your screen. E-mail is a clogged channel that desperately needs to be cleaned.

The problem is the e-mail system was designed as a simple personal communication channel over the fledgling Internet. Its trusting nature makes it too easy to spoof the system. It is trivial to manipulate the records in the e-mail to make it seem like the mail you send, was actually sent by, say, the CEO of your company. And there is little chance you will be discovered. Spammers can hide their tracks easily, because there is no way to accurately determine where in the world an e-mail was sent from.

That could be the first problem to be fixed. Yahoo! just published a proposed modification to the e-mail channel called DomainKeys. It will definitively associate the server that sends the e-mail, to the message itself, stripping away the layer of anonymity protecting spammers. After all that talk by Bill Gates about spam, Microsoft also released its own proposed solution to the same problem called Caller ID. Yahoo! and Hotmail are probably the world largest e-mail service providers, and this is the first concrete step to combat malicious mail.

The new problem, of course, is will these two work together to create a common solution, or are we facing a DVD-wars-like split in technology that will leave a hole wide open for spammers to drive through?



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